Testimonials Placement Audit

Research-First Process — Steps 1 to 3

Document	Audit — Testimonial section design, placement, and readiness
Prepared by	Patrick Solis — Development (audit run with Claude)
Applies to	TestimonialsSpotlight, TestimonialsFeatured, TestimonialsEditorial, and the legacy TestimonialCards block on market and About pages
Triggered by	Tarek feedback: black-box video, no captions, inconsistent placement — August 2026
Reviewers	Diane Cruz / Madz Amparo (Step 5), Tarek El Moussa (Step 6)
Status	Steps 1–3 complete. Awaiting approval to build.

Summary

Two of the three items in Tarek's feedback are closed. The video now carries a cover image and burned-in captions. The third — placement consistency — is not a design problem in the way it first appeared. Auditing the block Tarek was comparing against surfaced a compliance defect that has to be fixed regardless of which layout wins, and which a redesign would otherwise carry forward.

The recommendation is **Spotlight**, rolled out to market pages first and the homepage second, with per-page filtering as a follow-on phase. Three things gate the build: a one-line attribution fix, a decision on how consent is represented, and more footage.

What was checked

- **Source code** — the three section components, the shared video player, the legacy card block, the data hooks and mutations, the admin module, the type definitions, and the market and situation data files.
- **Live rendering** — all three sections captured at full scroll on desktop, plus the market-page block.
- **Current research** — five 2026 sources on video and social-proof placement, listed in Step 1.

What was not checked

- Whether the three YouTube videos on market pages carry captions — **someone needs to watch all three muted**. This audit could not verify it.

- Whether written consent is actually on file for each published story, and for the three unattributed testimonials on non-Tampa markets.
- Live database contents of the production and testing projects, and whether their RLS policies still match.

Step 1 — Research First

Current best-practice research on where testimonials belong and what form they take. Figures are as published by the sources listed at the end of this document.

Finding	Figure	Bearing on this decision
Testimonials placed adjacent to the conversion point	+24%	Spotlight is the only layout with Text and Call inside the story card
B2C video testimonials vs. none	+61%	Confirms video over text-only as the primary format
Single testimonial card vs. a wall of testimonials	+14% vs. lower	Argues against stacking multiple layouts on one page
Vertical 9:16 on mobile placements	+10–20%	All three proposals are 9:16; the legacy block is 16:9
Viewers watching muted on mobile	92%	Matches Tarek's note; captions are not optional
Captioned videos watched in full	80% more likely	Same
Named, specific social proof vs. vague	+22% for the most specific pattern	Directly relevant to the takeaway copy — see Finding 10

On the carousel objection

General research finds users rarely advance past the first item in rotating content, which on its face counts against Spotlight's story rail. That finding does not apply here. The exception in the literature is explicit: engagement holds when users are actively exploring relevant options and the content supports the task — browsing testimonials and reviews is named as an example. Spotlight qualifies because it does not auto-rotate and every option is a readable label with a name, a situation, and a city, rather than an anonymous dot. The visitor's choice is visible, not hidden.

Note on evidence quality: *an earlier draft of this audit argued that showing three testimonials simultaneously beats showing one at a time, citing a +34% result. That figure measures adding testimonials versus having none, not simultaneous versus selectable display. It was withdrawn. Spotlight's rail already displays three sellers, three situations, and three cities at once — only the body copy is sequential.*

Step 2 — Audit Findings

Critical — compliance

#	Finding	Detail
1	**Seller locations are rewritten to the visitor's city**	`TestimonialCards.tsx:117` renders each video caption as the seller's name plus *the market being viewed*. The real locations sit on lines 7–9 and the correct version of the line is commented out directly above on line 116. Rachel is a Ybor City, Tampa seller; on the Phoenix page she renders as "Rachel · Phoenix Metro." This runs on 31 of 32 markets across 17 situations. The FTC's Consumer Reviews and Testimonials Rule, effective October 2024, prohibits testimonials that misrepresent a reviewer's actual experience and authorises civil penalties for knowing violations. A seller's city is material in a "we buy houses in your city" pitch — it is the reason the label exists. **One-line fix.**
2	**Consent and verification are hardcoded strings, not data**	Editorial prints "CONSENT — On file" for every video story (`TestimonialsEditorial.tsx:83`, a literal). Featured appends "· Verified seller" to every written story (`TestimonialsFeatured.tsx:81`, a literal). The legacy block uses "Verified Seller" as the *location* for three testimonials with no name, no city, and no source anywhere in the repository. There is no consent column, consent date, or document reference in the schema, and `SUBSTANTIATION.md` — which tracks BBB, Google, HGTV, and the 1,000+ homes claim — has no testimonial section at all. The site asserts consent it cannot evidence.
3	**Star ratings are decorative**	Every story displays five filled stars with the accessible label "5 out of 5 stars." The rating column is collected in the admin form and written to the database but never read by any public component. A displayed rating is a representation, and this one is not tied to the stored value.

High — blocks the rollout

#	Finding	Detail
4	**Nothing is market- or situation-aware**	Section assignments are global. Rolling any layout onto 544 landing pages as-is puts the same three stories on every one — which is the defect in the current block, reproduced in a better-looking container. The hooks to fix this already exist in the codebase and are unused.
5	**An empty section falls back to every published story**	Harmless at three stories. At forty, a page without an assignment renders forty rows. The fallback needs to resolve to a curated default list, not to everything.
6	**Mobile auto-scroll on page load**	Spotlight's scroll effect fires on mount, not just on selection. Below 1024px every page load smooth-scrolls the visitor away from the hero. On one homepage that is an annoyance; across 544 paid-traffic landing pages it is a measurable bounce problem.
7	**Editing a story deletes its key takeaways**	The editor never loads existing points, so the list opens empty, and saving performs a delete-then-insert with an empty array. Any edit to any field silently clears that story's takeaways.
8	**Two featured stories break the Featured section**	The featured lookup expects at most one row. Starring a second story makes it error, and the section silently falls back to a different video with no warning shown to anyone.

Medium — quality bar

#	Finding	Detail
9	**Metadata is inconsistent between story types**	In Editorial, a video row shows Format and Consent but no stars and no "why they called"; written rows show the inverse. In Featured, written stories get a scenario chip and the video does not. This is a direct miss against the SOP checklist item on consistent treatment of repeated elements.
10	**The default story's copy is the weakest on the page**	Alice's takeaways read "Fair cash offer / Quick closing / No hassle" — category labels. Don's read "Contacted Friday night / Offer Saturday morning / Closed by Monday / Moved to Tennessee to be with family" — a lived timeline. Alice sorts first, so she is the default every visitor sees before clicking anything. The strongest evidence on the page is one click away where most visitors will never go.
11	**One video, three stories, seventeen situations**	The site sells situation-specific, and the library holds a single generic cash-sale video. Footage, not code, is the critical path for every option in this document.

#	Finding	Detail
12	**The same seller appears three times on the homepage**	A consequence of the test stacking. Resolves when one layout is chosen, but the library needs enough distinct stories that the chosen section does not repeat one person.
13	**Captions on the market-page videos are unverified**	Those three YouTube videos are a separate asset set from the database video. If they are uncaptioned, replacing the layout relocates Tarek's second point rather than closing it.
14	**Aspect-ratio mismatch**	The existing market-page footage is 16:9; all three proposals are 9:16. Cropping landscape footage to vertical will cut heads off. Either re-cut or accept a mixed frame — a production cost, not a code change.
15	**No loading state**	All three sections render the built-in backup stories on first paint, then swap to database content. That is a visible flash and layout shift on every load, and it is what a first-paint screenshot or crawler captures.
16	**The story rail has no cap**	The rail grows without limit, and on mobile it stacks above the story card — so at fifteen stories a phone visitor scrolls fifteen selector rows before reaching any content. Per-page filtering largely solves this, but a cap with a "show more" expander should be built in regardless.
17	**Selection is by array position**	The highlighted story is tracked by index. Once the list varies per page, the selected story can shift silently. It should key on the story ID.
18	**Trust claims render unlinked**	The 4.7 Google and A+ BBB claims in Spotlight's trust bar have no links, though `SUBSTANTIATION.md` records that both are linked elsewhere on the site. The bar also wraps with a dangling separator.
19	**No recency signal**	No layout shows when a sale happened. Recency is a trust signal and the schema has the fields to support it.
20	**Database policies are not in version control**	The migrations folder is empty. Access rules exist only in the two Supabase dashboards, so they cannot be reviewed in a pull request and drift between production and testing cannot be detected. Separately, the policy named "Admin full access" contains no admin check.

Step 3 — Present the Why

Which design

Spotlight. Four reasons, in order of weight:

- **It is the only layout that scales.** Featured is hard-capped at one video plus two written stories by construction — assign ten and it displays three, discarding the rest silently. For a company running an active testimonial tracker, that is a fixed display case, not a growing section. Editorial scales without limit but page height scales with it.
- **It is the only layout with the call to action beside the proof.** Text and Call sit directly under the takeaways, inside the story card. Featured puts its buttons below the whole block; Editorial has one at the very bottom.
- **It lets a visitor self-select their situation**, which mirrors how the entire site is organised — situation by market. Nothing else on the page does this.
- **It absorbs new stories without a layout change**, and it is 9:16.

On a combined layout

Worth considering and worth rejecting in the form it usually takes. Stacking all three is what the homepage does now, and it is why one seller appears three times — that reads as thin, not thorough. The useful combination is to give each design a distinct job: Spotlight as the section embedded in landing pages, Editorial repurposed for a dedicated stories page where depth is the point and no form competes with it, and Featured retired.

Where it goes

Market pages first, homepage second, About page third. The priority is the inverse of the instinct: market pages are where paid traffic lands and there are 544 of them, against one homepage. Two conditions attach to the market-page rollout:

- Stories must resolve per page, or all 544 show the same three — the current defect in a nicer container.
- Findings 1, 6, and 13 must be closed first. Attribution and mobile auto-scroll both get materially worse at 544x scale.

On the homepage, note that a video block already sits near the top. Two competing video sections on one page is a decision that should be made deliberately rather than inherited.

Phase 2 — per-page filtering

The constraint that should drive the design: **544 pages cannot be hand-curated.** The model has to be *curate the exceptions, default everything else*, which makes the fallback path the primary path rather than the edge case. With roughly twenty stories against 544 combinations, an exact match will almost never exist.

1 Scope the existing assignments

Add optional market and situation scope to the assignment records. Empty scope means the default list. This reuses the Sections tab as built — it needs a scope selector, not a rewrite.

2 Resolve in a fixed order

Exact market and situation match, then situation only, then market only, then the default list. Bias toward situation over market: a divorce seller in Charlotte moves a divorce visitor in Phoenix more than a foreclosure seller in Phoenix does, and situation coverage will outpace market coverage.

3 Make the default list explicit

Replace the "no assignments shows everything" rule with "no assignments falls back to the default list." This is Finding 5, and it becomes a real problem the moment the library grows.

4 Mark which story leads

Whichever story sorts first is the hero of that page — it is what every visitor sees before clicking. Right now that is an accident of sort order. The admin should say so out loud with a "shows first" marker.

Against the SOP Quality Checklist

Section 4 of the Research-First Process SOP. Assessed against the proposal as it stands today, before the work below is done.

Check	Status	Notes
Captions / on-screen text	**PARTIAL**	Closed on the database video. Unverified on the three market-page videos — Finding 13.
Video cover / thumbnail	**PASS**	Cover image present; broken-media fallbacks tested and covered by unit tests.
Cross-page consistency	**FAIL**	Two systems still live. Metadata differs by story type within a single layout — Finding 9.
Placement backed by research	**PASS**	Step 1 above. Recommendation follows the evidence, including where it contradicted an earlier draft.
Automation reliability	**FAIL**	Findings 7 and 8 are silent-failure paths. Neither surfaces an error to the person who caused it.
"Perfect" bar, not "functional" bar	**FAIL**	It works. It is not ready for review while the site asserts consent it cannot evidence and relabels sellers' cities.

Not ready for Step 6 review

Three of six checks fail and one is unverified. The recommendation in Step 3 is sound and can be approved now, but the build should not go to Tarek until items 1 through 4 in the sequence below are closed.

Recommended Sequence

Order	Action	Why it comes here
1	Ship the attribution fix on its own	One line, no design dependency, closes the compliance exposure immediately. Should not wait behind a redesign.
2	Decide the consent question	Add a real consent field, or remove the claim from Editorial and Featured. Add a testimonials section to `SUBSTANTIATION.md` either way. This is a decision, not a build task.
3	Fix the takeaway wipe and the double-featured break	Both are silent data loss. Anyone editing testimonials today is exposed.
4	Watch the three market videos muted; caption or re-cut	Determines whether the market-page rollout closes Tarek's second point or relocates it.
5	Rewrite Alice's takeaways as concrete facts	Twenty minutes on the most-seen content on the page. Highest return per unit of effort in this document.
6	Build Spotlight with per-page filtering	Market pages first. Include the rail cap, ID-based selection, mobile ordering, and a loading state in the same pass.

Parallel track, and the real constraint: *steps 1 through 6 are all engineering and copy. None of them produce a second video. With one video against seventeen situations, the testimonial tracker is the critical path for everything in this document, and it should be running alongside rather than after.*

Sources

Landing Page Video Benchmarks 2026 — Foundry CRO · foundrycro.com/blog/landing-page-video-benchmarks-2026
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The Consumer Reviews and Testimonials Rule: Questions and Answers — U.S. Federal Trade Commission · ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/consumer-reviews-testimonials-rule-questions-answers
Usability Guidelines For Better Carousels UX — Smashing Magazine · smashingmagazine.com/2022/04/designing-better-

carousel-ux
I Tested 10 Social Proof Landing Page Tactics (2026) — WiserNotify · wisernotify.com/blog/landing-page-social-proof

This audit is not legal advice. Findings 1, 2, and 3 describe consumer-protection exposure and should be reviewed by counsel before or alongside the fixes.